that the US improvement of relations with India was a “good move.” He had noted that India was not a major threat, since it did not have the capacity to attack or even encircle China, but agreed with Kissinger that Moscow might use India against China.[67] By late 1975, Deng seemed convinced that India was seeking good relations with China and believed that even the Indian public did not want too much dependence on Moscow.[68] For a while, Chinese policymakers had been hesitant about a rapprochement with India because of their concern about the Pakistani reaction, and Deng continued to worry about Indian pressure on Pakistan.[69] However, even on this front, there had been positive developments from the Chinese perspective.

India had worked to stabilize relations with Pakistan. The two countries had resumed talks in 1973 and, along with Bangladesh, had signed a tripartite agreement in April 1974. The subsequent nuclear test had stalled the improvement in India-Pakistan relations, as had India’s takeover of Sikkim, domestic preoccupations related to Gandhi’s declaration of an emergency, and the Sino-Pakistani reaction to the military coup in Bangladesh. However, by late 1975–early 1976, there again seemed to be progress, with India and Pakistan moving to implement the Shimla Accord of 1972 further and sending ambassadors to the other country.[70]

Combined with this, by late 1975 Deng told Ford he was pleased with how India-Soviet relations were developing—or not developing. Just as years earlier Nehru had been convinced that Sino-Soviet differences would grow over time, Beijing’s own experience with Moscow left Deng convinced that Delhi’s problems with Moscow would naturally increase.[71] By 1976, both China and the US indeed perceived a “cooling” between India and the Soviet Union.[72]

Ironically, this was the period during which Sino-US rapprochement stalled a bit. Kissinger had noted to Ford that Sino-Indian rapprochement had a downside for the US: Beijing would feel less threatened. But Chinese desire for friendship with the US had not decreased. Rather, Beijing was upset with the lack of movement toward full normalization on the US side. Chinese officials expressed their growing frustration directly and through countries like Pakistan. When Kissinger informed the Chinese foreign minister that normalization would not be completed by the time Ford was scheduled to visit at the end of 1975, Chinese leaders felt let down,